VOLUME 3

Reader Questions

Questions on Difficult Bible Verses



READERS QUESTION SERIES

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Volume 3: Questions on Difficult Bible Verses

HOW TO READ THIS VOLUME

Each entry takes one question a reader has asked about one verse or short passage. It states what the verse means, and then argues that meaning from the verse's own passage and the chapter or chapters before it. The Scripture elsewhere is used as support, not as the foundation. Each entry marks what the text states, what the context shows, and what is inferred, so that the reader can see what carries the weight and judge it. The entries argue a position. Where other readings are held by named writers, they are set beside it with the places where each strains.

Scripture is quoted from the King James Version (KJV). Modern writers are named by author and work; their views are described in the entry's own words, and no quotation marks are used for them.

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1. What Does “Take Up His Cross, and Follow Me” Mean in Matthew 16:24?

THE ANSWER

This is Kingdom-discipleship instruction, spoken by Christ in his earthly ministry to Israel’s disciples. “Take up his cross” is the figure of a condemned man: self-denial, readiness to suffer and loyalty to the Messiah as they follow him toward the promised kingdom, with the reward when the Son of man comes “in his kingdom.” It is the requirement for Israel’s remnant and it is not a command to the Body of Christ, which is never told to take up a cross or to follow Jesus on his earthly path. The Body’s word is that it is “crucified with Christ.”

Where the Verse Stands

The saying comes at a turn in the Gospel. Peter has just confessed, “Thou art the Christ, the Son of the living God” (16:16). “From that time forth” the Lord begins to show his disciples that he must suffer, be killed and be raised (16:21). Peter takes him aside and rebukes him, and the Lord answers, “Get thee behind me, Satan.” Only then does he turn to all the disciples and say what following him costs.

Verse	KJV text	What to observe
16:16	“When Jesus came into the coasts of Caesarea Philippi, he asked his disciples, saying, Whom do men say that I the Son of man am? And they said, Some say that thou art John the Baptist: some, Elias; and others, Jeremias, or one of the prophets. He saith unto them, But whom say ye that I am? And Simon Peter answered and said, Thou art the Christ, the Son of the living God.”	Peter: “the Christ, the Son of the living God.”
16:21–23	“From that time forth began Jesus to shew unto his disciples, how that he must go unto Jerusalem, and suffer many things of the elders and chief priests and scribes, and be killed, and be raised again the third day. Then Peter took him, and began to rebuke him, saying, Be it far from thee, Lord: this shall not be unto thee. But he turned, and said unto Peter, Get thee behind me, Satan: thou art an offence unto me: for thou savourest not the things that be of God, but those that be of men.”	The first announcement of death. Peter’s refusal; the Lord’s rebuke.
16:24–26	“Then said Jesus unto his disciples, If any man will come after me, let him deny himself, and take up his cross, and follow me. For whosoever will save his life shall lose it: and whosoever will lose his life for my sake shall find it. For what is a man profited, if he shall gain the whole world, and lose his own soul? or what shall a man give in exchange for his soul?”	The saying. The same word is “life” and “soul.”

Gal 2:20	“I am crucified with Christ: nevertheless I live; yet not I, but Christ liveth in me: and the life which I now live in the flesh I live by the faith of the Son of God, who loved me, and gave himself for me.”	To the Body: “I am crucified with Christ.”

What Carries the Weight

- **Stated:** the saying is spoken to “his disciples” and follows directly on the announcement that he will be killed and Peter’s refusal to hear it. “Let him deny himself” is said to the man who has just said, “this shall not be unto thee.”
- **Stated:** the reason is “for my sake,” and the exchange is the man’s “life” (the same word is rendered “soul” in 16:26) against “the whole world.” Whoever will save it shall lose it; whoever will lose it for the Lord’s sake shall find it.
- **Stated:** the saying looks forward to a reckoning: “the Son of man shall come in the glory of his Father with his angels; and then he shall reward every man according to his works” (16:27). Some standing there will see “the Son of man coming in his kingdom” (16:28).
- **Shown by the context:** the hearers are Israel’s disciples, and the setting is the kingdom: the confession is “the Christ,” the reward is at the Son of man’s coming, and the same cost is put to the “great multitudes” in Luke 14:25–27. These are Israel’s disciples following their Messiah toward the promised earthly kingdom, and nothing in the setting is addressed to a company called out of the nations.
- **Inferred:** that “his cross” is the figure of a condemned man carrying the instrument of his own execution. The text does not describe the figure, and the argument rests on the Lord’s announcement of his own death just before it.
- **Inferred:** that the saying is not a command to the Body. Paul never repeats it, and the Body is never told to follow Jesus in his earthly path. His word to the Body is that it has been crucified with Christ and that the cross is the ground of its standing, not a load to be taken up (Galatians 2:20; 6:14).

The Other Readings

Any hardship a believer bears. The saying is often applied to whatever burden life brings: an illness, a hard marriage, a difficult relative. It must explain why a cross, which was carried to an execution, became a figure for something endured at home, and why the Lord joins it to “for my sake.” **The call to every follower in every age.** Many take the cross as the suffering and rejection that come to anyone who follows Christ, a reading that keeps the figure of death. It must explain why the Body is given as a command what its own apostle gives as a finished fact. **The first disciples’ readiness to be rejected and killed.** The saying is read first as the readiness of the Lord’s own disciples to share his rejection and death. That is the reading taken here, with the added point that its setting is Israel’s kingdom and not the Body’s.

Reading	What it must say	Where it strains
Any hardship	The cross is whatever burden life brings.	A cross was an execution, not a burden; “for my sake.”
Every follower, every age	The cost of any disciple’s following.	Galatians 2:20 and 6:14 speak of the cross as finished for the Body.
The first disciples’ readiness	The Twelve are called to follow the King into rejection.	Luke 9:23, “daily,” must be read as repeated readiness.

What It Means for the Reader

This is program-specific instruction and not a universal rule for every believer. It shows what the King asked of the men who followed him on the road to Jerusalem, and what he promised them at his coming. The Body is not asked to earn anything by it. The Body's word is the other one: the cross was borne for it, and it is told that it died with Christ.

Related Reading

Digital Studies: Study 2, The Gospel of the Kingdom, reads the kingdom message to Israel as written; this entry argues a position on one saying. **Commentary Series:** Gospel, Volume 4 (What the Twelve Understood). **Companions:** Matthew.

2. What Does “Out of Egypt Have I Called My Son” Mean in Hosea 11:1 and Matthew 2:15?

THE ANSWER

Hosea 11:1 looks back. It is the Lord’s own word that Israel, his covenant son, was called out of Egypt at the exodus. Matthew applies the same line to Jesus, God’s eternal Son, whose flight into Egypt and return re-live Israel’s pattern. These are two sons, each in his own place: Israel in national sonship, Christ in his own Sonship. Matthew’s use is typological fulfilment, not a transfer of identity: Israel remains Israel, and Jesus does not replace Israel. He does not claim that Hosea was predicting the infant’s journey.

Where the Verses Stand

Matthew 2 tells of Joseph’s flight with the child and his mother to Egypt and of their stay “until the death of Herod,” and then gives the quotation. In Hosea 11 the Lord speaks of Israel’s childhood, of the nation’s turning to the Baalim after he called it, and of his refusal to give it up. The two passages are about the same name for the same people.

Verse	KJV text	What to observe
Hos 11:1–4	“When Israel was a child, then I loved him, and called my son out of Egypt. As they called them, so they went from them: they sacrificed unto Baalim, and burned incense to graven images. I taught Ephraim also to go, taking them by their arms; but they knew not that I healed them. I drew them with cords of a man, with bands of love: and I was to them as they that take off the yoke on their jaws, and I laid meat unto them.”	“When Israel was a child … called my son out of Egypt.” Then Israel’s turning away.
Mt 2:13–15	“And when they were departed, behold, the angel of the Lord appeareth to Joseph in a dream, saying, Arise, and take the young child and his mother, and flee into Egypt, and be thou there until I bring thee word: for Herod will seek the young child to destroy him. When he arose, he took the young child and his mother by night, and departed into Egypt: And was there until the death of Herod: that it might be fulfilled which was spoken of the Lord by the prophet, saying, Out of Egypt have I called my son.”	The flight to Egypt, the stay, and “that it might be fulfilled.”

What Carries the Weight

- **Stated:** Hosea 11:1 is about Israel in the past: “When Israel was a child, then I loved him, and called my son out of Egypt.” The next verse reports what Israel did after it was called.
- **Stated:** the title is Israel’s from the exodus. At the burning bush the Lord tells Moses to say, “Israel is my son, even my firstborn … Let my son go” (Exodus 4:22–

23).

- **Stated:** Matthew writes that the flight and return came to pass "that it might be fulfilled which was spoken of the Lord by the prophet," and quotes only Hosea's opening clause.
- **Shown by the context:** Matthew sets the same pattern in his next chapters. The Son is brought out of Egypt, passes through water (3:13–17), and is led into the wilderness, where he answers each temptation from Deuteronomy 6–8, the passage that recalls Israel's forty years.
- **Shown by the context:** Matthew opens by calling the child "the son of David, the son of Abraham" (1:1). He is writing of Israel's King, who passes through the places Israel passed through. Israel is God's son in one sense and the King is his Son in another, and neither stands in the other's place.
- **Inferred:** that "fulfilled" means the pattern re-lived by the eternal Son, and not a prediction hidden in Hosea and not the replacing of Israel. The text does not define the word, and the argument rests on the past tense of Hosea 11:1 and on the wilderness parallel Matthew himself supplies.

The Other Readings

A direct prediction. A reading common in popular apologetics takes Hosea 11:1 as a prophecy of the Messiah's return from Egypt that Matthew simply records as fulfilled. It must explain why Hosea speaks of Israel "when … a child" and goes on at once to Israel's idolatry, which cannot be said of the infant. **Matthew's freer reading.** Raymond Brown (*The Birth of the Messiah*) describes Matthew's quotations as an interpretive use of Israel's Scriptures in the light of Jesus, in which a likeness of experience is enough to link the texts. It leaves the link resting on the evangelist's method. **A pattern completed by the true Son.** R. T. France (*Matthew*, Tyndale New Testament Commentary) and Craig Blomberg (his treatment of Matthew in *Commentary on the New Testament Use of the Old Testament*, edited by Beale and Carson) take the fulfilment as a correspondence between the nation's experience and the Messiah's. That is the reading taken here, with the added point that the two sons stay distinct.

Reading	What it must say	Where it strains
A direct prediction	Hosea foretold the infant's return.	Hosea 11:1 is past, and 11:2 is about Israel's sin.
Matthew's freer method	A likeness of experience is enough.	The link then rests on Matthew, not on the sonship the Lord names.
A pattern re-lived	The eternal Son passes through the places Israel passed through.	"Fulfilled" is not defined; the case rests on Matthew's own parallel.

What It Means for the Reader

The verse is a reminder of who is in view when the Lord says "my son." In Hosea it is Israel; in Matthew it is the King, whose Sonship is his own. Neither is the Body, which has no exodus and no covenant sonship in Israel's sense. This is Israel's line of Scripture, and the Body's place in Christ is spoken of elsewhere and in other terms.

Related Reading

Digital Studies: Study 71, The Genealogies of Jesus, reports Matthew's opening as written; this entry argues a position on one quotation. **Commentary Series:** Typology, Volume 4 (Exodus Typology), and Gospel, Volume 2 (The Lord's Ministry to Israel). **Companions:** Hosea and Matthew.

3. What Does “Quench Not the Spirit” Mean in 1 Thessalonians 5:19?

THE ANSWER

The command is given to the Body of Christ. To quench the Spirit is to stifle or hinder his present-age ministry in the believer: his teaching, his work of growth and his work of sanctification. The Body quenches him by resisting his teaching through Paul’s doctrine, by rejecting truth, or by persisting in the flesh. It is a warning against stagnation. It is not about losing salvation or losing the Spirit, since God “hath also given unto us his holy Spirit,” and it is a different command from “grieve not the holy Spirit” in Ephesians 4:30.

Where the Verse Stands

The sentence is one of a run of short commands that close the letter. They begin with how the believers treat their leaders and one another (5:12–15), turn to joy, prayer and thanks (5:16–18), and then give four separate commands (5:19–22). The letter has already said what God wants of these believers: “this is the will of God, even your sanctification” (4:3), and he has “also given unto us his holy Spirit” (4:8). It closes with the prayer that God will “sanctify you wholly” (5:23).

Verse	KJV text	What to observe
5:12–15	“And we beseech you, brethren, to know them which labour among you, and are over you in the Lord, and admonish you; And to esteem them very highly in love for their work’s sake. And be at peace among yourselves. Now we exhort you, brethren, warn them that are unruly, comfort the feebleminded, support the weak, be patient toward all men. See that none render evil for evil unto any man; but ever follow that which is good, both among yourselves, and to all men.”	Leaders, peace, the unruly, the feebleminded, “one another.”
5:16–18	“Rejoice evermore. Pray without ceasing. In every thing give thanks: for this is the will of God in Christ Jesus concerning you.”	Rejoice, pray, give thanks: “the will of God in Christ Jesus.”
5:19–22	“Quench not the Spirit. Despise not prophesyings. Prove all things; hold fast that which is good. Abstain from all appearance of evil.”	Four short commands: quench, despise, prove, abstain.

What Carries the Weight

- **Stated:** “Quench” is the word for putting out a fire. The Spirit is not said to be put out; what is hindered is something he is doing in those to whom the command is given, and the verse is a command to believers who have him.
- **Stated:** the letter has set the Spirit’s work beside sanctification: God “hath not called us unto uncleanness, but unto holiness,” and “who hath also given unto us his holy Spirit” (4:7–8). The closing prayer is for sanctification “wholly,” and the letter adds that God “will do it” (5:23–24).

- **Shown by the context:** the four commands of 5:19–22 are separate. "Despise not prophesyings" is its own command, regulating how the Thessalonians treat prophetic utterances during the overlap, and it does not define quenching. The verse itself does not say how the Spirit is quenched, and the letter's own subject is the believers' holiness and growth.
- **Shown by the context:** the Spirit has already been given (4:8), and God is the one who will finish the work (5:24). A believer cannot take the Spirit away by quenching him, and nothing in the passage suggests it.
- **Inferred:** that quenching is the hindering of the Spirit's ministry of teaching and sanctifying in the believer's own life: resisting truth, refusing Paul's teaching and persisting in the flesh. The verse does not state the means, and the argument rests on the letter's theme of sanctification and on the Body's being the audience.

The Other Readings

Stifling the Spirit's manifestations in the congregation. Some take the command as aimed at a community that might suppress the Spirit's manifestation among them, especially prophecy, and read the figure of fire in the same setting, joined to the next verse. The reading is a serious one. It must explain why the command is not set beside prophesyings alone in a letter whose subject is holiness, and the next verse can be read as a separate command. **Resisting the Spirit's prompting in one's own life.** A common devotional reading takes quenching as the believer's answering conviction with disobedience, so that the Spirit's guidance is dimmed. That is the reading taken here, with the added point that the Spirit's present-age ministry is teaching and sanctification and not signs, wonders or prophetic manifestations.

Reading	What it must say	Where it strains
Stifling manifestations in the gathering	The assembly suppresses what the Spirit gives.	The command is one of four, and the letter's theme is holiness.
Hindering his teaching and sanctifying	The believer resists truth and persists in the flesh.	The verse does not state the means; the case rests on the letter's theme.

What It Means for the Reader

The verse gives no ground for fearing that the Spirit can be lost. It warns a believer against stagnation: against resisting what the Spirit teaches through Paul's doctrine and against staying in carnality when God has called him to holiness. Ephesians 4:30, "grieve not the holy Spirit of God," is a separate command and is taken up in Volume 1.

Related Reading

Digital Studies: Study 44, Walking in the Spirit, and Study 45, Sanctification Under Grace, report the passages as written; this entry argues a position on one verse.
Companions: 1 Thessalonians.

4. What Does "Work Out Your Own Salvation with Fear and Trembling" Mean in Philippians 2:12?

THE ANSWER

It is a word to the Body about living out the salvation it already has, and it is not about earning or keeping it. "Work out" means to bring to full expression what God has already worked within; the matter is sanctification, not justification. "Fear and trembling" is seriousness, humility and dependence on God's enabling, and the very next verse says so: "it is God which worketh in you both to will and to do of his good pleasure." It is instruction for the Body's spiritual maturity and is not Kingdom-discipleship language.

Where the Verses Stand

The letter is written "to all the saints in Christ Jesus which are at Philippi" (1:1), to people who are already saved. Its first chapter speaks of a company under pressure and urges them to "stand fast in one spirit" (1:27). Chapter 2 asks for lowliness and unity, sets before them Christ's humbling of himself, and then says "Wherefore." The command about salvation is the conclusion of that appeal, and it is followed by "Do all things without murmurings and disputings."

Verse	KJV text	What to observe
1:27–30	"Only let your conversation be as it becometh the gospel of Christ: that whether I come and see you, or else be absent, I may hear of your affairs, that ye stand fast in one spirit, with one mind striving together for the faith of the gospel; And in nothing terrified by your adversaries: which is to them an evident token of perdition, but to you of salvation, and that of God. For unto you it is given in the behalf of Christ, not only to believe on him, but also to suffer for his sake; Having the same conflict which ye saw in me, and now hear to be in me."	"Stand fast in one spirit"; "to you of salvation, and that of God."
2:12–13	"Wherefore, my beloved, as ye have always obeyed, not as in my presence only, but now much more in my absence, work out your own salvation with fear and trembling. For it is God which worketh in you both to will and to do of his good pleasure."	"Wherefore … work out your own salvation"; "it is God which worketh in you."

What Carries the Weight

- **Stated:** the command is addressed to those who have "always obeyed," and it carries its own correction in the next verse: God is the one who works in them, both the willing and the doing. The verb is "work out," not "work for."
- **Stated:** in Ephesians 2:8–9 the same apostle writes that salvation is "not of works, lest any man should boast." Salvation is God's gift, and what is worked out in Philippians is what God has already given.

- **Shown by the context:** the letter is written to saints and its subject is their conduct: lowliness (2:3–4), the mind of Christ (2:5), no "murmurings and disputings" (2:14), unity of mind (4:2). "Work out" falls on this ground as the bringing of their saved life to full expression.
- **Shown by the context:** Paul himself uses "salvation" of a present deliverance in 1:19, written from prison. The word in this letter is not confined to the moment of being saved.
- **Inferred:** that "salvation" in 2:12 is the saved life brought to full expression, that is, sanctification, and not justification or the gift by which they were saved. The letter does not define the word, and the argument rests on the verb "work out," on 2:13 and on the setting.

The Other Readings

The believer's growth in holiness. The command is read as the believer's progress in sanctification, to be worked out in daily life by the power God supplies. That is the reading taken here. **The well-being of the community.** Gordon Fee (*Paul's Letter to the Philippians*, New International Commentary on the New Testament) reads the command as the community's task of living out its salvation together in the face of pressure. It must explain why the command is "your own." **Salvation kept by effort.** Some systems take the verse as saying that final salvation depends on the believer's own work. It cannot stand with "it is God which worketh in you," or with the verses that say salvation is "not of works."

Reading	What it must say	Where it strains
Growth in holiness	The believer works out his sanctification.	The command is plural and the setting is an assembly.
The company's well-being	The assembly lives out God's gift together.	"Your own" points to each one's own life.
Salvation kept by effort	The believer's works secure his salvation.	2:13 and Ephesians 2:8–9 say God works, and it is "not of works."

What It Means for the Reader

The verse is not a warning that a believer's salvation hangs on how hard he works. It tells the saved to bring God's work in them to full expression, in humility and with reverence for the One who is doing it, and it gives them the reason: God is working in them. It is the Body's instruction for maturity and has nothing to do with Israel's covenant obedience or the requirements of the kingdom.

Related Reading

Digital Studies: Study 45, Sanctification Under Grace, Study 46, Secure in Christ, and Study 15, Faith and Works in James and Paul, report the passages as written; this entry argues a position on one verse. **Companions:** Philippians.

5. What Does “Deliver Such an One unto Satan” Mean in 1 Corinthians 5:5?

THE ANSWER

This is the Body’s own discipline. Paul tells the assembly at Corinth, gathered with his spirit and the power of the Lord, to remove a brother who persists in open immorality from its fellowship, putting him outside the protective sphere of the gathered assembly and so out into the world where Satan holds sway, “for the destruction of the flesh, that the spirit may be saved in the day of the Lord Jesus.” The “destruction of the flesh” is disciplinary affliction, physical or circumstantial, that God permits when the man is removed from the assembly’s protection, aimed at breaking the sinful pattern. The man is a brother, the purpose is corrective and aimed at restoring him, and the second letter shows him grieved and received back. It is corrective and not punitive: not a curse, not annihilation, not the loss of salvation and not Israel’s covenant penalty.

Where the Verses Stand

Chapter 5 begins with a report: there is fornication at Corinth, “such fornication as is not so much as named among the Gentiles,” and the assembly is “puffed up” instead of mourning. Paul has already “judged,” and the sentence of verse 5 is the judgment. He then explains that the putting out concerns “any man that is called a brother” and not the world outside.

Verse	KJV text	What to observe
5:1–5	“It is reported commonly that there is fornication among you, and such fornication as is not so much as named among the Gentiles, that one should have his father’s wife. And ye are puffed up, and have not rather mourned, that he that hath done this deed might be taken away from among you. For I verily, as absent in body, but present in spirit, have judged already, as though I were present, concerning him that hath so done this deed, In the name of our Lord Jesus Christ, when ye are gathered together, and my spirit, with the power of our Lord Jesus Christ, To deliver such an one unto Satan for the destruction of the flesh, that the spirit may be saved in the day of the Lord Jesus.”	The sin; the assembly “gathered together”; “deliver such an one unto Satan.”
2 Co 2:5–8	“But if any have caused grief, he hath not grieved me, but in part: that I may not overcharge you all. Sufficient to such a man is this punishment, which was inflicted of many. So that contrariwise ye ought rather to forgive him, and comfort him, lest perhaps such a one should be swallowed up with overmuch sorrow. Wherefore I beseech you that ye would confirm your love toward him.”	“Sufficient … is this punishment”; “forgive him, and comfort him.”

What Carries the Weight

- **Stated:** the act is the assembly's. It is done "when ye are gathered together," in the name of the Lord Jesus and with his power (5:4), and Paul explains it in 5:13 in other words: "put away from among yourselves that wicked person."
- **Stated:** the man is "called a brother" (5:11), and the purpose is "that the spirit may be saved in the day of the Lord Jesus" (5:5). The sentence has his salvation as its end.
- **Shown by the context:** Paul distinguishes the assembly from the world. The world outside is the sphere the Scriptures put under "the god of this world" (2 Corinthians 4:4) and "the prince of the power of the air" (Ephesians 2:2). To be put out is to be set back on that side, without the assembly's fellowship and shelter.
- **Shown by the context:** the second letter speaks of one who has been punished by "many," whom they are now to "forgive … and comfort," lest he be "swallowed up with overmuch sorrow" (2 Corinthians 2:6–7). It keeps the aim of the putting out: the man's return.
- **Inferred:** that the "destruction of the flesh" is disciplinary affliction, bodily or circumstantial, that God permits while the man stands outside the assembly's protection, aimed at breaking the sinful pattern, "the flesh," so that he may be restored. The text does not describe the affliction, and the argument rests on the stated purpose, "that the spirit may be saved," and on the second letter's picture of a man grieved and forgiven.

The Other Readings

A curse that casts him off. Handing the man over to be lost cannot stand with "called a brother" or "that the spirit may be saved." **Affliction of the body.** Many take the flesh as the man's body, afflicted under Satan's hand, with the spirit saved at the last. **The end of the old self-reliant life.** Gordon Fee (*The First Epistle to the Corinthians*, New International Commentary on the New Testament) takes the flesh as the carnal nature, destroyed through a remedial process, and Anthony Thiselton (*The First Epistle to the Corinthians*, New International Greek Testament Commentary) discusses and favours a sense of "flesh" as the self-centred orientation rather than the body, which discipline is meant to destroy. Both of these kinds of reading fall under corrective discipline, and the entry takes the affliction as the circumstantial or bodily suffering that outside the assembly's protection brings, aimed at breaking the sinful pattern. The man is saved either way.

Reading	What it must say	Where it strains
A curse; the man lost	He is handed over for ruin.	"Brother"; "the spirit may be saved."
Affliction of the body	God permits bodily or circumstantial suffering.	The verse does not name the affliction.
The old life broken	The flesh is his self-ruled pattern, broken by discipline.	It stretches the usual sense of "destruction of the flesh."

What It Means for the Reader

The verse is a pattern for an assembly dealing with open sin in one who bears the Lord's name. It is for his good, it is done together, and it is not a sentence on his salvation. Israel's procedure in Matthew 18:15–17 is a different matter.

Related Reading

Digital Studies: Study 46, Secure in Christ, reports the passages on security as written; this entry argues a position on one verse. **Companions:** 1 Corinthians.

6. Who Are “the Spirits in Prison” in 1 Peter 3:19?

THE ANSWER

They are angelic beings and not human souls: the angels who sinned in the days of Noah, now held in prison for judgment (2 Peter 2:4; Jude 6). After he was “quickened by the Spirit,” Christ made a proclamation to them. The word is the herald’s word, a declaration of his victory and of their judgment, and it is not an offer of the gospel to the dead. The passage ends with “angels and authorities and powers being made subject unto him.” It is written to Israel’s scattered believers and has no connection with the Body’s heavenly calling.

Where the Verses Stand

Peter writes to “the strangers scattered” (1:1), Israel’s scattered believers, who are suffering for doing right. Chapter 3 tells them that it is better, if God wills, to suffer for well doing than for evil doing (3:17), and then gives the reason: Christ also suffered, the just for the unjust, was “quickened by the Spirit,” and went and preached to the spirits in prison. The passage closes with Christ in heaven and every power subject to him.

Verse	KJV text	What to observe
3:18–22	“For Christ also hath once suffered for sins, the just for the unjust, that he might bring us to God, being put to death in the flesh, but quickened by the Spirit: By which also he went and preached unto the spirits in prison; Which sometime were disobedient, when once the longsuffering of God waited in the days of Noah, while the ark was a preparing, wherein few, that is, eight souls were saved by water. The like figure whereunto even baptism doth also now save us (not the putting away of the filth of the flesh, but the answer of a good conscience toward God,) by the resurrection of Jesus Christ: Who is gone into heaven, and is on the right hand of God; angels and authorities and powers being made subject unto him.”	Put to death, “quickened by the Spirit”; “preached unto the spirits in prison”; “angels and authorities and powers.”

Gen 6:1–4	“And it came to pass, when men began to multiply on the face of the earth, and daughters were born unto them, That the sons of God saw the daughters of men that they were fair; and they took them wives of all which they chose. And the Lord said, My spirit shall not always strive with man, for that he also is flesh: yet his days shall be an hundred and twenty years. There were giants in the earth in those days; and also after that, when the sons of God came in unto the daughters of men, and they bare children to them, the same became mighty men which were of old, men of renown.”	“The sons of God” and “the daughters of men.”
2 Pe 2:4–5	“For if God spared not the angels that sinned, but cast them down to hell, and delivered them into chains of darkness, to be reserved unto judgment; And spared not the old world, but saved Noah the eighth person, a preacher of righteousness, bringing in the flood upon the world of the ungodly;”	“The angels that sinned” cast down; “the old world.”
Jude 6–7	“And the angels which kept not their first estate, but left their own habitation, he hath reserved in everlasting chains under darkness unto the judgment of the great day. Even as Sodom and Gomorrha, and the cities about them in like manner, giving themselves over to fornication, and going after strange flesh, are set forth for an example, suffering the vengeance of eternal fire.”	Angels “reserved in everlasting chains under darkness.”

What Carries the Weight

- **Stated:** the beings are “spirits” “in prison,” and the disobedience is dated: “Which sometime were disobedient, when once the longsuffering of God waited in the days of Noah” (3:20).
- **Stated:** Christ’s act is put in the Greek with the herald’s verb, which Peter does not use when he speaks elsewhere of preaching the gospel (1:12; 4:6). It is a proclamation, not a gospel offer.
- **Stated:** the passage closes with the outcome: he “is gone into heaven, and is on the right hand of God; angels and authorities and powers being made subject unto him” (3:22).
- **Shown by the context:** Peter’s letter to his own suffering readers is meant to give courage. Christ suffered, was made alive, and won; hostile powers do not stand outside his rule. A word of victory to rebel powers belongs to that argument, and a second chance for the dead does not.
- **Shown by the context:** Second Peter 2:4–5 sets “the angels that sinned,” cast into “chains of darkness,” beside “the old world” of the flood, and Jude 6–7 joins angels held in “everlasting chains” to Sodom. The prison of the spirits of Noah’s day is the prison of those angels, and Volume 2, entry 9, takes up the sons of God of Genesis 6.
- **Inferred:** that the proclamation was made after the resurrection (“quickened by the Spirit,” 3:18) and before or at his going into heaven (3:22). The text does not state

the time or the place, and the entry does not name them.

The Other Readings

Christ preaching through Noah. Wayne Grudem (*1 Peter*, Tyndale New Testament Commentary) holds that Christ by his Spirit preached through Noah to the people of Noah's day, who are now spirits in prison. It must explain why the preaching is placed after he was "quickened," and why the spirits are "in prison" now and not the people of that generation. **A preaching to the dead.** An older tradition has Christ go to the place of the dead to preach to those who had died. Grudem (*Systematic Theology*) discusses and rejects it. It must explain why the herald's verb is used and why only the disobedient of one generation are named. **A proclamation of victory to fallen angels.** J. Ramsey Michaels (*1 Peter*, Word Biblical Commentary) takes the spirits as the demonic offspring of the fallen angels of Genesis 6, though he is far from dogmatic about it, and other commentaries read the spirits as the angels themselves. Both read the proclamation as the declaration of his triumph. That is the reading taken here, with the spirits as the beings of Genesis 6.

First Peter 4:6, "the gospel preached also to them that are dead," is a different statement. It speaks of those to whom the gospel was preached and who have since died, so that "they might be judged according to men in the flesh, but live according to God in the spirit." It uses the gospel verb of 1:12 and does not carry the spirits of chapter 3.

Reading	What it must say	Where it strains
Through Noah	Christ preached by his Spirit through Noah.	The preaching follows his being "quickened"; "spirits … in prison."
To the dead in Hades	He went and preached to those who had died.	The herald's verb; only one generation is named.
To fallen angels	He proclaimed his victory to the imprisoned angels.	Time and place are not stated.

What It Means for the Reader

The passage does not give a map of the unseen world, and it is not a message of salvation but a declaration of judgment, with no second chance for the dead. It is addressed to Israel's scattered believers and does not describe the Body's heavenly destiny. It tells believers who are suffering for righteousness that the One who suffered for them rose and sits on the right hand of God, and that no power, whether the imprisoned ones of Noah's day or the "principalities and powers" of Colossians 2:15, is outside his rule.

Related Reading

Digital Studies: Study 79, The Realms of the Dead, reports 2 Peter 2:4 and Jude 6 as written and does not decide the matter; this entry argues a position on Peter's words. **Companions:** 1 Peter.

7. What Is “the Sin unto Death” in 1 John 5:16?

THE ANSWER

It is physical death, not the loss of salvation, which God brings on a believer who persists in severe, unrepentant sin. It is a discipline of God and not a covenant curse: God takes the believer from earthly life to prevent further damage to his testimony, as in the Corinthians among whom “many are weak and sickly,” and “many sleep.” It is not eternal death, damnation or the loss of eternal life, and the passage is set in a letter written “that ye may know that ye have eternal life.” The apostle does not name the sin and does not forbid praying for such a brother. It is not the unpardonable sin of Matthew 12.

Where the Verses Stand

The letter closes with its purpose: “These things have I written unto you that believe on the name of the Son of God; that ye may know that ye have eternal life” (5:13). John then speaks of confidence in prayer (5:14–15) and applies it to a brother who sins. He says that there is a sin unto death and that there is a sin not unto death, and then closes the letter with three things “we know.”

Verse	KJV text	What to observe
5:10–13	“He that believeth on the Son of God hath the witness in himself: he that believeth not God hath made him a liar; because he believeth not the record that God gave of his Son. And this is the record, that God hath given to us eternal life, and this life is in his Son. He that hath the Son hath life; and he that hath not the Son of God hath not life. These things have I written unto you that believe on the name of the Son of God; that ye may know that ye have eternal life, and that ye may believe on the name of the Son of God.”	“Written … that ye may know that ye have eternal life.”
5:16–17	“If any man see his brother sin a sin which is not unto death, he shall ask, and he shall give him life for them that sin not unto death. There is a sin unto death: I do not say that he shall pray for it. All unrighteousness is sin: and there is a sin not unto death.”	A brother who sins; “a sin unto death”; “a sin not unto death.”
1 Co 11:30–32	“For this cause many are weak and sickly among you, and many sleep. For if we would judge ourselves, we should not be judged. But when we are judged, we are chastened of the Lord, that we should not be condemned with the world.”	“Many sleep”; “chastened of the Lord, that we should not be condemned with the world.”

What Carries the Weight

- **Stated:** the sinner is “his brother.” The one who asks is a believer, and the answer is given as “life.” The sin unto death is a sin of a brother.

- **Stated:** the letter states its own purpose: that those who believe "may know that ye have eternal life." The writer has just told believers they have it, and he says that "all unrighteousness is sin: and there is a sin not unto death."
- **Shown by the context:** the "life" given in answer to prayer is life rescued from death, not eternal life given again to one who has it. The pairing of "life" with "death" in 5:16 turns on a bodily death and the preservation from it.
- **Shown by the context:** in a letter Paul wrote to the Body, God judges believers with bodily death. He says of the Corinthians' abuse of the Supper that "many are weak and sickly among you, and many sleep" and that when "we are judged, we are chastened of the Lord, that we should not be condemned with the world" (1 Corinthians 11:30–32). The Body is not under Israel's law, but God still disciplines his children.
- **Inferred:** that John has this kind of discipline in view, a warning to the believer and not a covenant curse. He does not name the sin or say how it is known, and the argument rests on "his brother," on the purpose statement of 5:13 and on the pairing of "life" and "death." John himself separates sins that lead to physical death from those that do not.

The Other Readings

Apostasy or the denial of Christ. I. Howard Marshall (*The Epistles of John*, New International Commentary on the New Testament) and Raymond Brown (*The Epistles of John*, Anchor Bible) read the sin unto death in light of the letter's conflict with those who had left the community, as a deliberate refusal of the Son that leaves a person dead in sin. It fits the letter's earlier warnings. It must explain why the sinner is called "his brother" and why prayer is to obtain "life" for him. **Physical death as the Lord's judgment on a believer.** Some take the sin as one that God judges with the death of the believer's body. That is the reading taken here, with the added point that it is a discipline of God's children and no covenant penalty.

The unpardonable sin of Matthew 12:31–32 is a different matter. It was said of Israel's leaders in the presence of the King (Volume 2, entry 8), and John's words are about a brother, in a letter whose purpose is assurance.

Reading	What it must say	Where it strains
Apostasy, spiritual death	The sinner has turned from the Son.	"His brother"; "life" asked for him; 5:13.
Physical death as judgment	God takes the life of a believer who persists.	The sin is not named; this is the entry's inference.

What It Means for the Reader

The reader who fears he has committed this sin may rest on what the letter says. He has eternal life, which the apostle wrote to let him know. The passage calls a believer to pray for his brother, warns that God can judge a persisting sin, and does not name the sin, so the reader should not guess at it.

Related Reading

Digital Studies: Study 46, Secure in Christ, and Study 24, The Willful Sin Warning, report their passages as written; this entry argues a position on one verse.
Companions: 1 John.

8. What Does “The Just Shall Live by His Faith” Mean in Habakkuk 2:4?

THE ANSWER

The sentence has two program-specific applications that never merge. In Habakkuk, in Israel’s program, it is God’s answer to a prophet who cannot see how he can use a cruel nation to judge his own people: the proud man’s “soul … is not upright in him,” but Israel’s faithful remnant will keep its life through the coming national distress by trusting God’s promises, “though it tarry, wait for it.” In the Mystery, Paul takes the same sentence to teach that the saints of the Body live by faith apart from the Law (Romans 1:17; Galatians 3:11). The writer to the Hebrews uses it within Israel’s line, to call suffering believers to endure. It states a universal truth, and it works differently in each program’s own structure.

Where the Verse Stands

Habakkuk opens with a complaint about violence in Judah (1:2–4). The Lord answers that he is raising up the Chaldeans, “that bitter and hasty nation” (1:5–6). The prophet protests that God is “of purer eyes than to behold evil” and asks why he is silent when “the wicked devoureth the man that is more righteous than he” (1:13). He then stations himself to wait for an answer, and the Lord tells him to write the vision. The sentence about the just comes in the middle of that answer. The book ends with a prayer in which the prophet will rejoice in God though the fig tree does not blossom.

Verse	KJV text	What to observe
2:1–4	“I will stand upon my watch, and set me upon the tower, and will watch to see what he will say unto me, and what I shall answer when I am reproved. And the Lord answered me, and said, Write the vision, and make it plain upon tables, that he may run that readeth it. For the vision is yet for an appointed time, but at the end it shall speak, and not lie: though it tarry, wait for it; because it will surely come, it will not tarry. Behold, his soul which is lifted up is not upright in him: but the just shall live by his faith.”	“Write the vision … though it tarry, wait for it”; “the just shall live by his faith.”
3:17–19	“Although the fig tree shall not blossom, neither shall fruit be in the vines; the labour of the olive shall fail, and the fields shall yield no meat; the flock shall be cut off from the fold, and there shall be no herd in the stalls: Yet I will rejoice in the Lord, I will joy in the God of my salvation. The Lord God is my strength, and he will make my feet like hinds’ feet, and he will make me to walk upon mine high places. To the chief singer on my stringed instruments.”	“Although the fig tree shall not blossom … yet I will rejoice in the Lord.”

Ro 1:16–17	"For I am not ashamed of the gospel of Christ: for it is the power of God unto salvation to every one that believeth; to the Jew first, and also to the Greek. For therein is the righteousness of God revealed from faith to faith: as it is written, The just shall live by faith."	"The just shall live by faith."
Ga 3:10–12	"For as many as are of the works of the law are under the curse: for it is written, Cursed is every one that continueth not in all things which are written in the book of the law to do them. But that no man is justified by the law in the sight of God, it is evident: for, The just shall live by faith. And the law is not of faith: but, The man that doeth them shall live in them."	"No man is justified by the law … for, The just shall live by faith."
He 10:35–39	"Cast not away therefore your confidence, which hath great recompence of reward. For ye have need of patience, that, after ye have done the will of God, ye might receive the promise. For yet a little while, and he that shall come will come, and will not tarry. Now the just shall live by faith: but if any man draw back, my soul shall have no pleasure in him. But we are not of them who draw back unto perdition; but of them that believe to the saving of the soul."	"Ye have need of patience"; "the just shall live by faith: but if any man draw back."

What Carries the Weight

- **Stated:** the verse is a contrast: the one "lifted up" has a soul "not upright in him," and "the just shall live by his faith." The sentence closes an answer to a question about how the righteous are to stand when evil seems to prosper.
- **Stated:** the answer is a waiting: "the vision is yet for an appointed time … though it tarry, wait for it; because it will surely come, it will not tarry" (2:3). "His faith" is the steadiness of one who holds to that word while he waits.
- **Shown by the context:** the setting is a coming invasion. To "live" in the book is to keep his life through the judgment, as 3:17–19 shows: the man who has nothing, no fig tree, no flock, "yet" rejoices in the Lord and finds his strength in him.
- **Stated:** Paul uses the sentence in Romans 1:17 and Galatians 3:11, where it stands for the life that belongs to the man who is righteous by faith, in contrast to the law, and so teaches the saints of the Body that they live by faith apart from the Law. In Hebrews 10:38 it is joined with "the just shall live by faith: but if any man draw back," an appeal to those who had "endured a great fight of afflictions."
- **Inferred:** that the same sentence has two program-specific applications and does not carry the same content of faith in each. In Habakkuk, and in Hebrews within Israel's line, the faith is in what God has said to Israel: the vision, the promise, the One who is coming. In Romans and Galatians it is in the gospel Paul preaches to the Body. They are never merged. The text does not state this, and the argument rests on each passage's own words.

The Other Readings

Faithfulness in Habakkuk. Commentators on Habakkuk, Francis Andersen (*Habakkuk*, Anchor Bible) among them, discuss whether the Hebrew word means steadiness or faithfulness, so that the just man lives by his steadfast trust. The reading is close to

the one taken here, which does not hold that faith and faithfulness can be pulled apart in this verse, since the steady waiting is the faith. **The man righteous by faith shall live.** Commentaries on Romans discuss whether Paul means that the righteous man shall live by faith or that the man who is righteous by faith shall live. **One meaning everywhere.** It is often taught that the sentence carries one meaning, saving faith in Christ, in all four places. It must explain how Habakkuk could have meant the content Paul preaches, which the book does not state.

Reading	What it must say	Where it strains
Faithfulness in Habakkuk	The just man lives by his steady trust.	The waiting is itself the faith.
Righteous by faith shall live	Paul speaks of the man justified by faith.	It is Paul's use; Habakkuk's setting is the judgment.
One meaning in all four	Each writer means saving faith in Christ.	Habakkuk does not state that content.

What It Means for the Reader

The sentence is an answer to waiting. A person who trusts what God has said, and holds to it through a time when God seems slow, lives through the judgment that overtakes the proud. Paul takes the same sentence, in the Mystery, to show that the saints of the Body live by faith apart from the Law. Hebrews takes it within Israel's line to urge endurance. The truth is universal, but it does not merge Israel and the Body: what each is told to believe is what God has said in that program's own setting.

Related Reading

Digital Studies: Study 54, Justification, and Study 75, Faith Before the Cross, report the passages as written; this entry argues a position on one sentence. **Companions:** Habakkuk and Romans.

9. Who Are “the Meek” Who “Inherit the Earth” in Matthew 5:5?

THE ANSWER

This is Kingdom prophecy, spoken by Christ to Israel. The meek are Israel’s faithful remnant, those who wait on the Lord and leave vengeance to him, as Psalm 37 says in the very words the Lord uses: “the meek shall inherit the earth.” They are the ones who will enter and inherit the earthly kingdom of the Messiah. The Body of Christ does not inherit the earth: its destiny is “in heavenly places.” The promise belongs to Israel’s covenant hope and is not transferred to the Body.

Where the Verse Stands

The Sermon on the Mount follows a summary of the Lord’s work: “preaching the gospel of the kingdom” and healing, with crowds from Galilee, Decapolis, Jerusalem, Judaea and beyond Jordan (4:23–25). Seeing the multitudes, he goes up the mountain, and “his disciples came unto him.” The beatitudes are the opening of what he says. Each carries a promise, and two of them end in the same words: “for theirs is the kingdom of heaven” (5:3, 10).

Verse	KJV text	What to observe
Mt 5:3–10	“Blessed are the poor in spirit: for theirs is the kingdom of heaven. Blessed are they that mourn: for they shall be comforted. Blessed are the meek: for they shall inherit the earth. Blessed are they which do hunger and thirst after righteousness: for they shall be filled. Blessed are the merciful: for they shall obtain mercy. Blessed are the pure in heart: for they shall see God. Blessed are the peacemakers: for they shall be called the children of God. Blessed are they which are persecuted for righteousness’ sake: for theirs is the kingdom of heaven.”	The beatitudes; “theirs is the kingdom of heaven” at the first and the last.
Ps 37:9–11	“For evildoers shall be cut off: but those that wait upon the Lord, they shall inherit the earth. For yet a little while, and the wicked shall not be: yea, thou shalt diligently consider his place, and it shall not be. But the meek shall inherit the earth; and shall delight themselves in the abundance of peace.”	“Those that wait upon the Lord, they shall inherit the earth”; “the meek shall inherit the earth.”
Eph 1:3	“Blessed be the God and Father of our Lord Jesus Christ, who hath blessed us with all spiritual blessings in heavenly places in Christ:”	To the Body: blessed “in heavenly places in Christ.”

What Carries the Weight

- **Stated:** Matthew 5:5 repeats Psalm 37:11 almost word for word, and the psalm says who the meek are: those who “wait upon the Lord,” who do not fret at the

prosperity of the wicked and who “cease from anger” (37:7–9).

- **Stated:** the beatitudes are kingdom promises. The first and the last end with the kingdom of heaven, and the Lord’s own prayer in the same sermon asks, “Thy kingdom come. Thy will be done in earth, as it is in heaven.”
- **Shown by the context:** the psalm’s promise is repeated five times (37:9, 11, 22, 29, 34) and the word is “land” as often as “earth.” The promise is the earth under the reign of the righteous and the end of the wicked, and Isaiah 60:21 speaks of Israel’s inheriting “the land for ever.”
- **Shown by the context:** the audience is the Lord’s own disciples with the multitudes of Israel around them (4:25). The sermon is given to them, and it speaks of a kingdom they were told was “at hand.”
- **Inferred:** that “the earth” is the earth of the coming kingdom under the King, and not a spiritual possession or only the eternal state. The text does not say when, and the argument rests on the kingdom setting of the sermon and the psalm’s own words.

The Other Readings

The new earth and the age to come. Many commentaries take the inheritance as the consummated kingdom, the new earth, shared by all who belong to Christ. It must explain why the promise is stated in Israel’s words to Israel’s disciples and then widened to the Body. **The earth of the kingdom the King will rule.** Others take the promise as the earthly kingdom of the Messiah, which is the reading taken here, with the added point that it is spoken to Israel’s disciples and is not the Body’s inheritance. **A spiritual possession now.** Some take the promise as the meek having peace and the earth’s goods in a spiritual sense. It must explain why the psalm and Isaiah speak of the land.

Reading	What it must say	Where it strains
The new earth, for all believers	The meek share the consummated kingdom.	The setting is Israel’s; the promise is quoted from Israel’s psalm.
The earth of the coming kingdom	The meek inherit the kingdom’s earth.	The text does not give a date.
A spiritual possession now	The meek have rest and the earth’s goods in spirit.	“Land” and “earth” in Psalm 37 are not spiritual.

What It Means for the Reader

Meekness in Scripture is not weakness. Moses was “very meek, above all the men which were upon the face of the earth” (Numbers 12:3), and the King says of himself, “I am meek and lowly in heart” (Matthew 11:29). The verse promises that Israel’s faithful remnant, the ones who wait on the Lord and do not take vengeance, will be given the earth when the King reigns. It is part of Israel’s hope and not Pauline doctrine. The Body’s own promise is of another kind, “in heavenly places in Christ.”

Related Reading

Digital Studies: Study 62, Matthew 5:17–20, Study 56, Inheritance, and Study 41, Kingdom of God or Kingdom of Heaven, report their passages as written; this entry argues a position on one verse. **Commentary Series:** Gospel, Volume 1 (The Sermon on the Mount), and Prophecy & Mystery, Volume 3 (The Kingdom Program). **Companions:** Matthew and Psalms.

10. What Does “The Kingdom of God Is within You” Mean in Luke 17:21?

THE ANSWER

Jesus is speaking to Israel during his earthly ministry, to Pharisees who were asking when the kingdom would come, and he answers that it does not come with signs to be watched for, because the King himself stands “in the midst of” them. The words cannot mean that the kingdom was inside those men, who were rejecting him. It is a statement about the nearness of Israel’s promised kingdom, because the King was physically present. The visible kingdom in power is still ahead: he turns to his disciples and speaks of “the day when the Son of man is revealed.” It is not the Body’s heavenly kingdom and not an internal reign.

Where the Verse Stands

Luke 17 opens a stretch of teaching on the road to Jerusalem. The Pharisees have been described as “covetous” and as those who “justify yourselves before men” (16:14–15). After ten lepers are cleansed (17:11–19), they ask “when the kingdom of God should come.” The Lord answers them, and then, “unto the disciples,” speaks of days to come when they will desire to see one of the days of the Son of man.

Verse	KJV text	What to observe
17:20–21	“And when he was demanded of the Pharisees, when the kingdom of God should come, he answered them and said, The kingdom of God cometh not with observation: Neither shall they say, Lo here! or, lo there! for, behold, the kingdom of God is within you.”	“Not with observation”; “the kingdom of God is within you.”
17:22–25	“And he said unto the disciples, The days will come, when ye shall desire to see one of the days of the Son of man, and ye shall not see it. And they shall say to you, See here; or, see there: go not after them, nor follow them. For as the lightning, that lighteneth out of the one part under heaven, shineth unto the other part under heaven; so shall also the Son of man be in his day. But first must he suffer many things, and be rejected of this generation.”	To the disciples: days to come; “first must he suffer many things.”
11:20	“But if I with the finger of God cast out devils, no doubt the kingdom of God is come upon you.”	“The finger of God … no doubt the kingdom of God is come upon you.”

What Carries the Weight

- **Stated:** the question is put by Pharisees, and the Lord’s words are given as an answer to them: “he answered them and said.” The statement that it “cometh not with observation” and that men shall not say, “Lo here! or, lo there!” is a correction of their way of asking.
- **Stated:** the very next verse marks a change of audience: “And he said unto the disciples.” What follows is future: “the days will come,” “the Son of man … in his

day," "the day when the Son of man is revealed" (17:22, 24, 30).

- **Shown by the context:** the people addressed are the ones the Lord has just called self-justifying (16:15) and who, in 17:25, are part of "this generation" by which he is "rejected." The kingdom cannot be said to be inside them.
- **Shown by the context:** elsewhere the Lord says that his casting out of devils shows that the kingdom "is come upon you" (Luke 11:20). The kingdom was present in the King and his works among them, and they were rejecting both.
- **Inferred:** that the Greek word rendered "within" can also mean "among" (the KJV margin offers "among you") and that here it means "in the midst of you." The word does not decide it, and the argument rests on the audience and the next verses.

The Other Readings

An inner, spiritual kingdom. The verse is widely taken to say that God's kingdom is the reign of Christ in the believer's heart. The reading is common in devotional writing. It must explain why the Lord would say it to Pharisees he had just called self-justifying, and why in the next verses he speaks of a future revealing. **The King in their midst.** I. Howard Marshall (*The Gospel of Luke*, New International Greek Testament Commentary) and others take the sense as "among you," the kingdom present in the person and work of Jesus. That is the reading taken here, with the added point that the kingdom in power is future and is Israel's, and that the statement is not a description of the Body.

Reading	What it must say	Where it strains
Within the heart	The kingdom is Christ's reign inside a person.	It is said to Pharisees; 17:22–30 is future.
In the midst of them	The King stands among the men asking.	The Greek allows both; the case rests on the audience.

What It Means for the Reader

The verse is not a statement about a private inner life. It tells the Pharisees, and the reader, that the question of when the kingdom comes was being asked in front of the King, and that the open reign still lay ahead. The Body's own statement, "Christ in you, the hope of glory" (Colossians 1:27), is a different statement in a different letter and is not this one.

Related Reading

Digital Studies: Study 41, Kingdom of God or Kingdom of Heaven, and Study 2, The Gospel of the Kingdom, report their passages as written; this entry argues a position on one verse. **Commentary Series:** Prophecy & Mystery, Volume 3 (The Kingdom Program), and Gospel, Volume 2 (The Lord's Ministry to Israel). **Companions:** Luke.

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